**Activists in Canada topple statue, demand apology from pope amid reckoning over death of Indigenous children at residential schools**

By Miriam Berger and Amanda Coletta
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Protesters on Sunday toppled a statute of Egerton Ryerson — one of the key figures behind Canada's residential school system, which separated some 150,000 Indigenous children from their homes — amid growing anger over the Catholic Church's refusal to issue an apology for its role in the abuse students faced.

The rally at Ryerson University in Toronto was organized in response to news last month that the remains of 215 Indigenous children had been found in the yard of a former residential school run by the Catholic Church in British Columbia. Since the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc First Nation shared news of the unmarked burial site on May 27, members of the student body and Indigenous communities have renewed calls on the university to change its name and remove Ryerson's statue.

In the wake of the statue's toppling, university President Mohamed Lachemi said in a statement that it would "not be restored or replaced."

The university, Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau said at a forum there last week, "is going through a process right now around its own name, and I think what really matters is that these conversations be had in a responsible and mature fashion and that people are really listening."

Pressure has also been mounting on the Catholic Church to issue a formal apology for its role in running schools such as Kamloops Indian Residential School and to hand over all the records that might help to identify unmarked burial sites and the students who died or went missing. The Church has so far refused to do so, despite a request from Trudeau at a meeting in 2017.

"That there are still church records that have not been revealed or made available … is a sad commentary on the lack of the commitment by the Catholic Church to allow us to investigate this further," Murray Sinclair, a former chair of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission, told a parliamentary committee last week.

Rosanne Casimir, chief of the Tk'emlúps te Secwépemc First Nation, told reporters that she wants an apology from the Vatican. "We do want an apology — a public apology — not just for us, but for the world," she said.

Pope Francis on Sunday said during his weekly blessing in St. Peter's Square that he was pained by news of the remains and called for respect for native peoples' rights and culture.
But he conspicuously fell short of issuing a formal apology.

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